

Contextual Social App

Senior Product Design Review

Based on V2 Product Specification — Design Critique, Flaw Analysis & Recommended Fixes
Prepared from collaborative design session · May 2026

Core Concept	Social activation layer for physical spaces — lowering the activation energy of real-world conversation through mutual consent, contextual identity, and hint-based recognition.
Flaw Buckets	Structural (blocks core loop) · Detail gaps (confuse build) · Philosophy tensions (inconsistent decisions)
Design Principle	Reality-first: every decision is tested against — does this get people off their phones faster, or keep them on longer?

Understanding the Core Concept

This is not a messaging app, a dating app, or a social media feed. It is a social activation layer for physical spaces — scaffolding that lowers the cost of starting a real-world conversation between strangers who are already in the same room.

The Problem	In any given café, airport, or coworking space, 3–5 people would enjoy talking to each other — but don't.
The Insight	The app solves mutual consent (both people signal openness before any approach), recognition (both people know who they're talking to), and a shared context (both people have something in common).
The Product	The actual product is the conversation that happens in real life. The app is just the scaffolding. It's the "glue" that makes the conversation happen.

3-Layer Matching Model

Users become mutually visible only when all three layers align:

Layer 1 — Physical Proximity	Users are in the same venue at the same time.
Layer 2 — Shared Intent	Both users have selected compatible intentions: networking, open to conversation, group discussion, casual chat.
Layer 3 — Social Vibe	Contextual interest overlap: AI/startups, philosophy, travel, productivity, creativity, language exchange.

SECTION 2

What Works Well in V2



Presence State Machine

Invisible → Prompt Eligible → Prompted → Visible → Discoverable → Interaction Active → Expiring → Invisible. Every feature maps to a state. Developers can build from this. Safety team can reason about what's possible at each stage. This is production-quality thinking.



Hint Card System

The most original idea in the product. Bridges digital discovery to physical recognition without GPS exposure. 'Blue headphones' or 'Reading Dune' solves the recognition problem elegantly. Should be positioned higher in the spec — it's a key differentiator.



Notification Rules Engine

Dwell-time requirement (3–5 min), one prompt per venue per day, focus mode suppression, no passive activation. Together these form a coherent anti-fatigue system. Most apps skip this thinking entirely.



Session Expiry UX

The 5-minute warning, extension prompt, and 'You are now invisible nearby' end state are well-designed. Clean, satisfying, no ambiguity. Directly addresses the v1 gap.



Safety Embedded in Flow

Report and block on every profile card, hide user in feed, instant invisibility toggle. Safety is not an afterthought — it's integrated at every layer. Correct approach for a strangers-facing product.



Improved AI Prompts

The v2 prompts are specific enough to produce useful output. The backend prompt alone — TTL expiration, mutual visibility constraints, dwell-time logic — will generate a schema a developer can actually work with.



Beta Success Metrics

Presence activation rate, repeat activation rate, real-world interaction rate, session extension rate. These are behavioral metrics, not vanity metrics. They validate whether the core loop actually works.

SECTION 3

Identified Flaws & Recommended Fixes

Structural Problems

These block the core loop if unresolved. Fix before wireframing.

Critical

Mutual openness indicator is undefined

Problem: The spec mentions 'mutual openness indicators' in step 9 but never defines what they look like. This is load-bearing — it's the signal that tells someone the other person is open to being approached.

Fix: When both users share at least one intent or vibe, highlight a single shared tag in amber on the profile card. 'You both selected AI/startups.' Simple, factual, low-pressure. No score, no percentage.

Critical

Low-density silent failure

Problem: The notification rules engine requires 'meaningful social density' as a condition. If a user is alone at a venue, the app silently does nothing. They have no idea why. This is the biggest retention killer in the product.

Fix: Add a passive 'venue pulse' visible even when not activated: '3 people have been active here this week' or 'This spot is quiet — be the first to open up.' Reframes empty state as invitation, not failure.

Critical

The offline-to-reality transition is one line

Problem: Step 10 says 'users interact in real life' but this is the hardest moment in the entire experience. The spec doesn't design for the 30 seconds before someone walks over — where all the anxiety lives.

Fix: Add an 'approaching' micro-state. When you tap a profile and decide to approach, show one screen: their hint card large, the icebreaker suggestion, and a single 'I'm going over' button that dims the UI and starts a soft 60-second timer. A graceful push from digital to physical.

Detail Gaps

These create confusion during build. Resolve during wireframing.

Medium**'Save user' contradicts ephemeral philosophy**

Problem: The nearby feed includes a 'save user' action, but the platform's core philosophy is temporary, ephemeral presence. Saving creates a persistent social record that directly contradicts the product's identity.

Fix: Remove from MVP entirely. Replace with a single post-session prompt: 'Did you connect with someone today?' If yes, offer optional mutual contact exchange outside the app. The app doesn't hold the relationship.

Medium**Messaging ambiguity**

Problem: V2 says the app doesn't prioritise digital messaging, but the click paths still include a chat page. V1 had 'waves and lightweight messaging' as a feature. V2 is ambiguous about whether that survived.

Fix: Make a firm decision: waves only for MVP, no full chat. A wave signals interest without requiring words. If both people wave back, show the icebreaker — that's the handoff to real life. Chat can come in v3 if beta data supports it.

Medium**Venue page has no content hierarchy**

Problem: The venue page is defined in section 10 with 6 data points: visible users, vibes, intentions, clusters, energy level, density. No hierarchy — designers can't prioritise without it.

Fix: Top to bottom: social energy indicator (warm/cool), number of visible people now, active vibes as tags, then the list. No map, no exact positions. Answers 'is it worth activating here?' in one glance.

Medium**User flow text still reflects v1 trigger model**

Problem: The written steps 1–9 still say 'user enters venue' as step 1, but the diagram correctly shows background detection as the trigger. These two are out of sync.

Fix: Update the written steps to match the diagram. Step 1 should be 'Background system detects dwell time at social venue.' A dev team handed this doc will build the wrong trigger.

Philosophy Tensions

These cause inconsistent decisions downstream if unresolved in writing.

Tension

'Offline-first' vs entirely digital flow

Problem: The spec claims 'offline-first' but the entire user flow lives on a screen until step 10. The framing is aspirational, not descriptive.

Fix: Reframe internally as 'reality-first.' Every design decision gets tested against: does this get people off their phones faster, or keep them on longer? This becomes a shared team principle for consistent downstream decisions.

Tension

Semi-anonymous identity rules are incomplete

Problem: The spec lists what's 'initially visible' but doesn't define what gets revealed, when, and based on what trigger. Designers will interpret this differently.

Fix: Define a clear progressive reveal rule: first name and hint card always visible. Avatar and vibe visible only after tapping a profile. Intent visible only when it matches yours. Encode this as a rule, not a guideline.

SECTION 4

Recommended Week 1 Action Plan

Research First

Before any wireframes are drawn, do one afternoon of guerrilla research. Sit in a busy Helsinki café and observe how people signal openness or closed-ness through body language. Map those signals to the app's presence states. The hint card idea likely came from an insight like this. There are 2–3 more sitting in that café.

Three Screens to Wireframe First

These three screens are the entire product in terms of the moment that matters. Get these right before designing settings, onboarding, or admin.

1

Presence Activation Sheet

The core conversion moment. Must feel fast — defaults pre-filled from last session. Intent, vibe, duration, hint card, then one large 'Become Visible' button. Every second of friction here loses users.

2

Nearby Feed Card

The discovery surface. Show first name, vibe tag, intent tag, hint card, and the shared alignment signal if applicable. No full profile until tap. Must communicate enough to decide whether to approach without oversharing.

3

Approaching Micro-State

The moment before the walk-over. Hint card large. Icebreaker suggestion. 'I'm going over' button that dims the UI and starts a soft timer. This screen doesn't exist in the spec yet — it needs to be designed.

Decisions to Make Before Wireframing

- Waves only vs waves + lightweight messaging — commit to one for MVP
- Exact progressive reveal rules for identity (first name / avatar / intent / vibe)
- Minimum density threshold to run Helsinki beta meaningfully
- Beta launch date and what 'success' looks like in week 1 of beta
- Internal design principle: reality-first as a shared team rule

SECTION 5

Flaw Summary

Flaw	Category	Severity	Fix
Mutual openness indicator undefined	Structural	Critical	Shared tag highlighted on profile card
Low-density silent failure	Structural	Critical	Venue pulse + 'be first to open up' empty state
Offline-to-reality transition missing	Structural	Critical	Approaching micro-state screen
'Save user' contradicts philosophy	Detail	Medium	Remove; replace with post-session connection prompt
Messaging ambiguity	Detail	Medium	Waves only for MVP; no full chat
Venue page no content hierarchy	Detail	Medium	Define top-to-bottom hierarchy in spec
User flow text vs diagram mismatch	Detail	Medium	Update written steps to match diagram
'Offline-first' framing is inaccurate	Philosophy	Tension	Reframe as 'reality-first' design principle
Progressive reveal rules incomplete	Philosophy	Tension	Define explicit reveal rule per profile field

This review is based on a collaborative design session analyzing the V1 and V2 product specifications. The core concept is sound and the V2 spec represents a significant maturation. The identified gaps are addressable — none are structural to the business idea itself.